

The Best Places to Eat Eisbein

Zur Letzten Instanz expensive

Berlin's oldest restaurant has a real sense of history. There's been an inn on this spot since 1621, when a schnapps bar opened; it was still going strong when a conquering Napoleon Bonaparte visited in 1806. The present business dates back to 1924, when it was a popular stop on the way to the nearby courthouse. In honor of this, all the dishes here have been given legal-themed names like *Zeugen-Aussage* ("Eyewitness Account"), but it's the wood-clad interior and classic tiled oven that really preserve the historic feel. This, and its superb execution of Berlin's traditional dishes, make the place so authentic and so well known that foreign heads of state have often been brought here, including former Soviet statesman Mikhail Gorbachev and former French president Jacques Chirac. *Eisbein* is the most popular dish, but if you want something lighter, try a *boulette* – a ground meat and herb burger that's also a Berlin specialty and is done here to perfection.

Waisenstrasse 14–16, Berlin; open noon–11 PM Mon–Sat, noon–9 PM Sun; www.zurletzteninstanz.de

Also in Berlin

The plastic and Formica decor of **Schusterjunge (+49 30 442 7654; inexpensive)** reminds visitors of life in former East Germany, but this old-fashioned Berlin corner pub has built up a cult following for its mountainous portions of no-nonsense Berlin food, including *Eisbein*.

Also in Germany

Outside Berlin, genuine *Eisbein* is hard to find and pork knuckles are more commonly prepared as roasted *Schweinshaxe*, with mustard, horseradish, and pickled chili peppers. However, **Max Walloschke (www.max-walloschke.de; inexpensive)**, a friendly 1950s-style urban pub in Hanover, and the lovely old-fashioned **Restaurant Eisbeinhaus (+49 20 2251 4670; moderate)** in Wuppertal both serve wonderfully tender *Eisbein*, with giant portions of sauerkraut and mashed potatoes.

Around the World

Elsewhere in the world, authentic *Eisbein* is almost impossible to come by. However, in the US, **Mark's East Side (www.markseastside.com; moderate)** in Appleton, WI, is extremely competent at cooking German food and will serve *Eisbein* simmered, rather than roasted, if requested. Meanwhile, the slight inauthenticity of *Eisbein* in **Bar do Alemão (www.bardoalemaocuritiba.com.br; moderate)** in Curitiba, Brazil, can be forgiven once tasted; the addition of herbs and pickled salads gives this dish some South American flair and color.



Above Restaurant Zur Letzten Instanz ("To the Last Judgment") has counted Napoleon and Beethoven among its customers

Left The traditional German dish *Eisbein*, a slow-cooked knuckle of pork, is usually served with an accompaniment of sauerkraut